

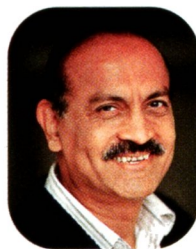
Time to Move On

Adversity does seem to bring out the best in Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. In Parliament during the debate on the Sharm el-Sheikh joint statement, he exhibited skills in debating reminiscent of the way he pushed through the Indo-US nuclear deal. He showed sincerity, humility, flexibility and patience in his replies and took much of the sting out of the Opposition's vicious attack. He explained the reasons for his big leap in faith in Pakistan's leadership at the Egyptian resort as the forward movement shown by Islamabad in bringing to book some top LET operatives, including its chief Zaki-ur-Rehman Lakhvi, for the Mumbai blasts. He also said how he had talked tough on terror to both Pakistan President Asif Zardari at Yekaterinburg and Prime Minister Yousuf Raza Gilani at Sharm el-Sheikh and told them explicitly that a meaningful dialogue was possible only if they brought the Mumbai attackers to book and not allow its territory to be used to perpetrate such activities. And then, quoting Ronald Reagan,

he added to India's foreign policy lexicon by stating that India needs to "trust but verify" in its relations with Pakistan and other neighbours. If the government's advisers had explained all this to the public in the run-up to Sharm el-Sheikh and the joint statement had reflected the prime minister's clarity on the issue, instead of contempt, Manmohan would have been hailed for his efforts to work for peace with Pakistan, the Balochistan slip-up notwithstanding.

All is not lost, though. While Manmohan may have expended precious political capital, Sharm el-Sheikh has shown to the international community that India can be magnanimous, as a big player should be, and has also put the ball right back in Pakistan's court to deliver. The carrot of a return to normal relations remains. These are some gains that can be worked on in the months ahead. The prime minister must now move on and concentrate on other major regions in the world. He must get the Ministry of External Affairs to prepare the ground for his visit to Washington DC in November so that he can move the relationship significantly forward.

He must quickly sign the Free Trade Agreement with ASEAN. He then needs to head to Saudi Arabia to woo the Middle East. As important is a longish trip to Africa where even US Secretary of State Hilary Clinton is paying a 11-day, seven-nation visit. A one-dayer to either Sri Lanka or Bhutan would help India's neighbourhood policy. Unlike what Yashwant Sinha predicted, much of the "sins" that the Opposition heaped on him for his initiative at Sharm el-Sheikh would be washed away by then.



DIED: Indian Union Muslim League Kerala President since 1975, **P.S.M. Shihab Thangal**, 73. He was a key player in

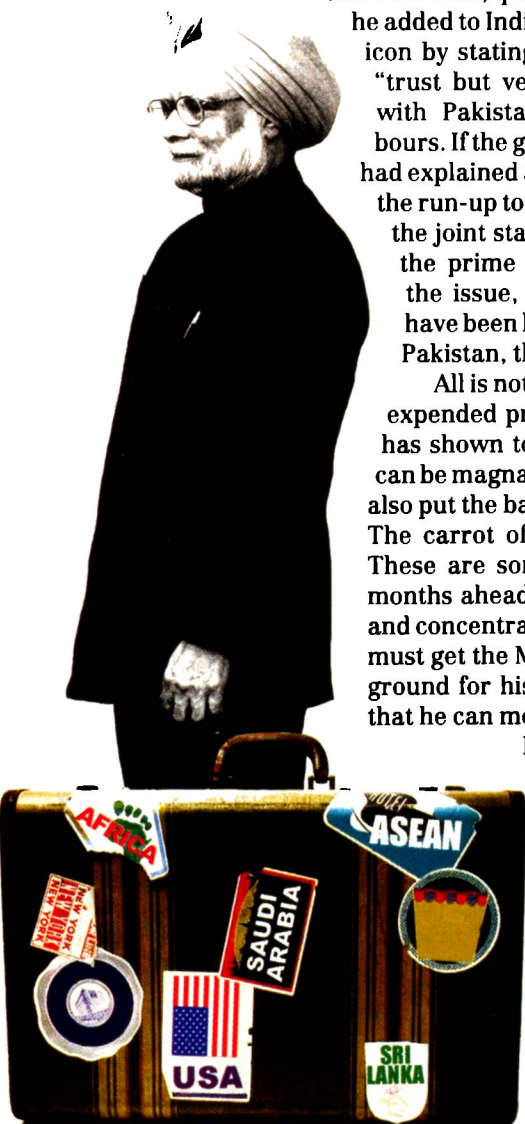


Kerala's coalition politics over the last three decades.

SELECTED: Boxers **M.C. Mary Kom** and **Vijender Singh**, and wrestler **Sushil Kumar** for the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna, the highest sporting honour. This is the first time that three sportspersons have been picked for this award in the same year.

WON: By **Deep Joshi**, the 2009 Ramon Magsaysay Award for his vision and leadership in bringing professionalism to the NGO movement in India.

DIED: **Subhas Chakraborty**, 68, CPI(M) leader and West Bengal minister for transport, sports and youth affairs.



SAURABH SINGH

IF MANMOHAN FOCUSES ON OTHER MAJOR REGIONS HE WOULD FIND THAT THE SO-CALLED "SINS" OF SHARM EL-SHEIKH WILL SOON WASH AWAY.